Xiuling Zhang

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Fields of Interest

African politics, ethnic and identity politics, gender and politics, political violence, political economy of development, China–Africa relations, experimental and computational methods.

Education

Ph.D. Candidate, Government and Politics, University of Maryland, College Park, expected spring 2027.

Subfields: comparative politics, [second field].
Dissertation: *Identity and Programmatic Politics in Africa*.
Committee: John F. McCauley (chair), Ernesto Calvo, Fiona Shen-Bayh, Giancarlo Visconti.

M.A. African Studies, University of California, Los Angeles, 2019.
B.A. International Politics and Economics (double major), Peking University, 2017.

Research

Job Market Paper

Whose Ethnicity Counts? Gender, Patriarchy, and Coethnic Voting in Nigeria

Abstract: Decades of research in comparative political behavior show that voters favor coethnic candidates, yet we know little about women's place in ethnic politics. I argue that female candidates compete on an uneven playing field in societies where ethnic identity is politically salient yet ethnic membership is structurally patriarchal. Where patrilineal conventions establish men as the primary anchors of ethnic membership, women's ethnic ties carry less weight in establishing coethnic status, leaving them with less ethnic capital to draw upon for electoral support. I examine these dynamics across two crucial dimensions of ethnic ascription: lineage and marriage. Drawing on conjoint experiments in Lagos, Nigeria, I show that paternal ethnic ties confer substantially greater electoral returns than maternal ones, regardless of candidate gender. In marriage, male candidates retain coethnic support when marrying outside their group and even gain support from their wives' communities. Female candidates, however, lose support from their ethnic communities of origin without gaining equivalent support from their husbands' communities. Crucially, this penalty holds even among female voters who otherwise favor female candidates. These findings highlight how patriarchal rules of ethnic ascription translate into distinct electoral disadvantages for women.

Dissertation

Identity and Programmatic Politics in Africa

Abstract: [Draft; please revise.] My dissertation asks how ethnic and gender identity shape the demand for, and the credibility of, programmatic politics in Africa. It argues that identity does not simply compete with programmatic appeals: the rules by which identity is ascribed and the rules by which benefits are allocated jointly determine whom voters reward. Drawing on original face-to-face conjoint and vignette experiments in Lagos and Maiduguri, Nigeria, the first chapter shows how eligibility rules and programme design condition the premium voters place on coethnic candidates. The second chapter (the job market paper) shows that patrilineal rules of ethnic membership translate into a distinct electoral disadvantage for women candidates. The third chapter shows that citizens hold politicians more accountable for violence against victims who share their identity, and that this bias fades where violence is perceived as indiscriminate. Together, the chapters trace how identity enters political evaluation through institutional rules rather than through attachment alone.

Peer-Reviewed Publications

1. Zhang, Xiuling, and John McCauley. "The US Inspires Dreams and China Gets Things Done: Gauging Global South Attachments to Major Powers with Evidence from Nigeria." *Peace & Democracy*, forthcoming.
2. Wang, Wei, Weisheng Zhang, Xinran Fan, and Xiuling Zhang. "High-Severity Environmental Alarms as Corrective Signals: Evidence from Beijing's First Red Haze Alerts." *Air Quality, Atmosphere & Health*, forthcoming.

Under Review

1. Zhang, Xiuling, John McCauley, and Trey Billing. "The Democratic Costs of Terrorist Attacks in Africa." Revise and resubmit, *Journal of Conflict Resolution*.
2. Zhang, Xiuling, and John McCauley. "Project Characteristics and Preferences over Foreign-Funded Initiatives: Evidence from Nigeria." Revise and resubmit, *Studies in Comparative International Development*.
3. Zhang, Xiuling. "Victim Identity and Political Blame: Evidence from Nigeria." Under review.

Other Work in Progress

1. Zhang, Xiuling, John McCauley, and Trey Billing. "Terrorist Attacks and the Religiosity of Survivors." Draft available upon request.
2. Zhang, Xiuling. "Eligibility, Identity, and Preferences for Programmatic Goods in Nigeria." Dissertation chapter.
3. Zhang, Xiuling, and Peter Steiner. "Optimal Block Design for Vignette and Conjoint Experiments in Political Science."

Selected Awards and Grants

2026, 2024	Comparative Politics Summer Grant, Department of Government and Politics, University of Maryland.
2025	Methods Summer Grant, Department of Government and Politics, University of Maryland.
2023	Summer Research Fellowship, Department of Government and Politics, University of Maryland.
2018	Hilton Global Summer Scholar Fellowship, UCLA World Policy Analysis Center.
2017, 2018	Dean's Scholarship, UCLA International Institute.
2016, 2017	Undergraduate Research Award, First Prize, Peking University.
2015–2017	Honor Student; Guanghua, Huang's, and Lujing Scholarships, Peking University.

Teaching

University of Maryland, College Park

Instructor of Record

GVPT 484: Government and Politics of Africa, Fall 2025.
GVPT 354: International Development and Conflict Management, Summer 2025 and Summer 2026.

Teaching Assistant

GVPT 203: The Challenge of Authoritarianism, [Professor], Spring 2026.

Conference Presentations

[Please list, most recent first, e.g.: APSA, "Title," Sep. 2026. MPSA, "Title," Apr. 2025. African Studies Association, "Title," Nov. 2024. Draft files named MPSA.docx (created Oct. 2023) exist in the conjoint and paper 1 folders.]

Professional Experience

2019–2021	Associate, Blackpeak Risk Consulting, Shanghai, China.
2018	ICT Project Assistant, International Institute of Tropical Agriculture (IITA), Kigali, Rwanda.
2016–2017	Trade Group Intern, Sino Africa Centre of Excellence Foundation, Beijing, China.
2016	Public Relations Intern, BCW (Burson Cohn & Wolfe), Beijing, China.

Service

2022–2023	Graduate Student Association Representative, Department of Government and Politics, University of Maryland.
2018–2019	Editor, *Ufahamu: A Journal of African Studies*, UCLA African Studies Center.

Miscellaneous

Languages: Mandarin (native), English (proficient), Swahili (conversational).
Programming: R, Python, Stata, ArcGIS, LaTeX, Git/GitHub.

References

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